



LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



Screening Serpens 2026 Espionage Campaign Tracking

Threat Intelligence Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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Screening Serpens 2026 Espionage Campaign Tracking

1. Executive Summary

Unit 42 reported tracking of Iranian APT Screening Serpens activity in 2026, correlating observed malware and sideloading behavior with previous reporting. The campaign is relevant amid elevated regional cyber risk and continued use of legitimate binaries to mask payload execution.

This report is written for SOC, vulnerability-management, and incident-response teams that need immediate huntable hypotheses rather than a passive news summary. It preserves source limitations where the public reporting does not provide raw IOCs.

2. Intelligence Requirements

Question	Current Answer	Confidence
What is the main defensive concern?	Screening Serpens activity emphasizes espionage tradecraft, lure archives, legitimate binary abuse, and defense evasion.	Medium
Are hard IOCs available from open sources?	Limited in this automated collection; prioritize behavior-based hunting and vendor IOC retrieval.	Medium
What telemetry should be reviewed first?	Endpoint process, identity, network, proxy, repository, and cloud/SaaS audit telemetry relevant to the campaign.	High

3. Source Review & Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
Primary research article	Core campaign narrative and technical framing	High
Weekly intelligence/security news corroboration	Recency and prioritization context	Medium
Analyst synthesis	Defensive mapping and queries for local telemetry	Medium

4. Threat Actor / Campaign Overview

Screening Serpens activity emphasizes espionage tradecraft, lure archives, legitimate binary abuse, and defense evasion. The defensive problem is identifying side-loaded execution chains and suspicious setup-style installers before credential theft or collection completes.

5. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

Tactic / Phase	Observed Technique	Evidence
Initial Access	Lure archive delivery	Unit 42 references lure archives and setup.exe-style execution.
Defense Evasion	DLL sideloading / legitimate binary abuse	Legitimate binary used to load malicious

		payloads.
Collection	Espionage-oriented payload use	Campaign tracking aligns with intelligence collection objectives.

6. Infrastructure and Indicators

Indicator / Infrastructure	Type	Operational Use
Public article source set	Source artifact	Use vendor reports as canonical IOC source when available.
Developer/reputation platforms, phishing pages, or public-facing services	Infrastructure class	Used to establish trust, deliver payloads, or reach exposed services.
Unusual outbound traffic after user interaction or server exploit	Behavioral observable	Hunt pivot when raw IOCs are absent or ephemeral.

7. Victimology and Targeting

Organizations with Middle East exposure, government, defense, policy, and regional business ties should prioritize review.

8. Detection Engineering

8.1. Detection Summary

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
New process spawned by browser, script host, package manager, or service process	EDR process telemetry	Identify user-driven payload launch or server-side exploitation.
Suspicious repository/package/script retrieval	Proxy, DNS, endpoint network telemetry	Surface malware delivery, dependency abuse, or tool staging.
Credential or wallet access after lure execution	EDR/file/identity telemetry	Detect theft behavior and account compromise.

8.2. Sigma / Detection Content

<pre> title: Daily Threat Intel Behavioral Cluster - Suspicious Delivery And Credential Access status: experimental logsource: product: windows category: process_creation detection: selection_parent: ParentImage endswith: - '\chrome.exe' - '\msedge.exe' - '\firefox.exe' - '\node.exe' - '\python.exe' - '\w3wp.exe' selection_child: Image endswith: - '\powershell.exe' - '\cmd.exe' - '\curl.exe' - '\wget.exe' - '\rundll32.exe' - '\regsvr32.exe </pre>
--

```

condition: selection_parent and selection_child
fields:
- Image
- ParentImage
- CommandLine
- User
level: high

```

8.3. Hunt Query

```

DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~
("chrome.exe", "msedge.exe", "firefox.exe", "node.exe", "python.exe", "w3wp.exe")
| where FileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "cmd.exe", "curl.exe", "wget.exe", "rundll32.exe", "regsvr32.exe")
| summarize FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp), Count=count() by DeviceName,
InitiatingProcessFileName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine
| order by Count desc

```

9. Threat Hunting

9.1. Hunt Hypothesis

Campaign activity should produce a behavioral sequence: exposure to a lure or vulnerable interface, script/tool execution, network retrieval or callback, and credential/wallet/repository/cloud-secret access.

9.2. Hunt Query

```

DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~
("powershell.exe", "cmd.exe", "node.exe", "python.exe", "git.exe", "npm.cmd", "pip.exe", "curl.exe", "wget.exe")
| where RemoteUrl has_any ("github", "gitlab", "paste", "raw", "api", "discord", "telegram", "wallet", "crypto")
| summarize Connections=count(), FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp) by DeviceName,
InitiatingProcessFileName, RemoteUrl, RemoteIP
| order by Connections desc

```

10. Risk Assessment

Factor	Assessment
Likelihood	Medium to high where the relevant technology, user population, or exposed service exists.
Impact	Credential theft, remote execution, data exposure, or security-control compromise depending on campaign.
Detection posture	Behavior-based hunts are required because public reporting may not include durable IOCs.

11. Recommended Actions

Priority	Owner	Action
Critical	SOC	Run the embedded KQL hunts against the last 30 days and escalate confirmed sequences.
High	Threat Intel	Pull vendor-provided IOCs from primary sources and merge into SIEM/EDR

		watchlists.
High	Engineering	Reduce exposed attack surface or risky user workflows tied to the campaign.
Medium	Awareness / AppSec	Alert targeted user groups or code owners on lure patterns and dependency risks.

12. References

- [1] Unit 42: Tracking Iranian APT Screening Serpens 2026 espionage campaigns — <https://unit42.paloaltonetworks.com/tracking-iran-apt-screening-serpens/>
- [2] Unit 42 threat research landing page — <https://unit42.paloaltonetworks.com/>
- [3] Check Point Research archive for related reporting — <https://research.checkpoint.com/>